



A village in the valley of the Congo River in Africa in the 1800s. Congolese territory was put under the control of the Belgian king, Leopold II, in 1885.

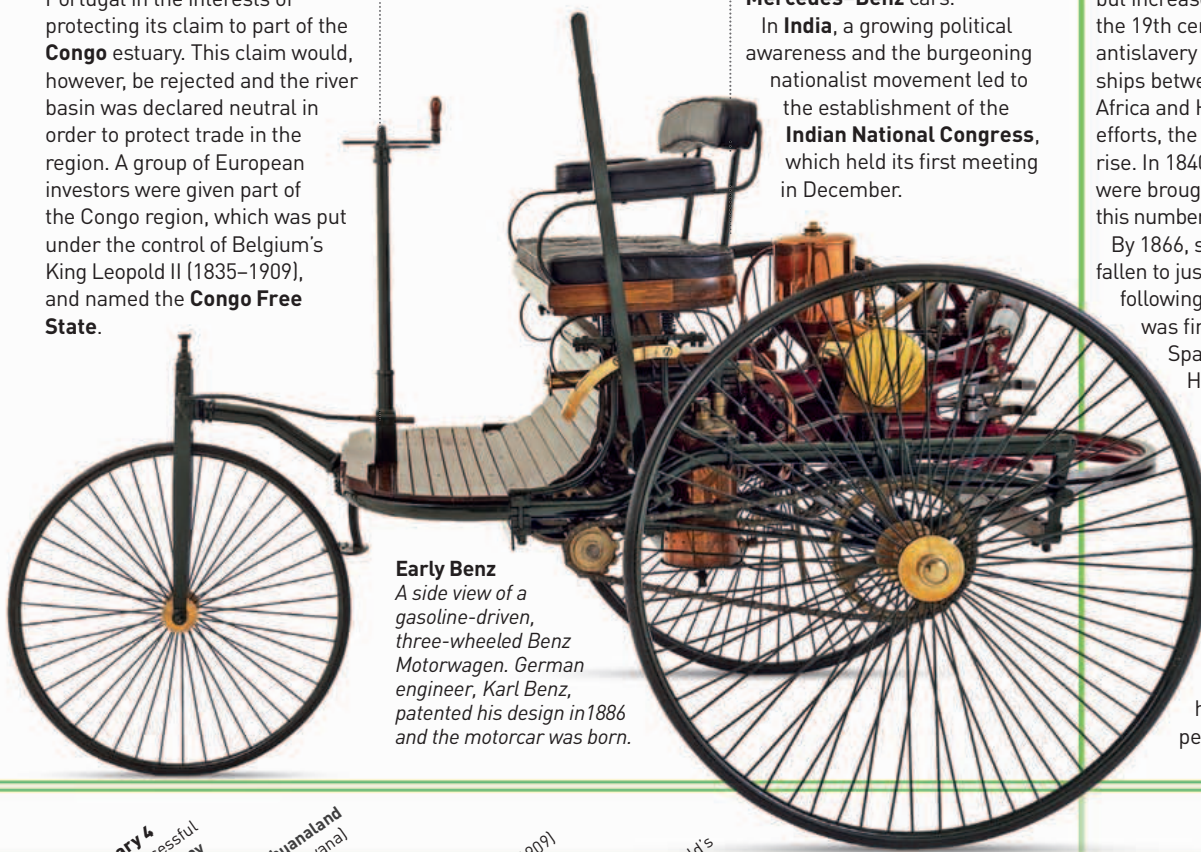
AS SOME OF THE NATIONS IN EUROPE became more powerful—especially the new nations of Germany and Italy—they were eager to participate in the growing European colonization of overseas territories, notably in Africa. To this end, the **Berlin Conference on Africa** was held from November 15, 1884 until February 26, 1885. Later known as the meeting that triggered the “**Scramble for Africa**,” competing powers jostled for territory—although no African leaders were even consulted, much less invited. The meeting was initiated by Portugal in the interests of protecting its claim to part of the **Congo** estuary. This claim would, however, be rejected and the river basin was declared neutral in order to protect trade in the region. A group of European investors were given part of the Congo region, which was put under the control of Belgium’s King Leopold II (1835–1909), and named the **Congo Free State**.

“**BESIDE LEOPOLD, NERO, CALIGULA, ATTLA, TORQUEMADA, GENGHIS KHAN AND SUCH KILLERS OF MEN ARE MERE AMATEURS.**”

Mark Twain, American author, on Leopold II’s regime in the Congo

Meanwhile, in Germany, engineer **Gottlieb Daimler** (1834–1900) patented a high-speed internal-combustion engine. Daimler and partner Wilhelm Maybach (1846–1929) conducted further research with the engine, placing it on bicycles and carriages. Around the same time fellow German **Karl Benz** (1844–1929) had also been experimenting with engines. He came up with the idea for the Benz car, and in 1885 assembled the **first automobile** in the world. He set up Benz & Co, which would later merge with Daimler to make **Mercedes-Benz** cars.

In **India**, a growing political awareness and the burgeoning nationalist movement led to the establishment of the **Indian National Congress**, which held its first meeting in December.



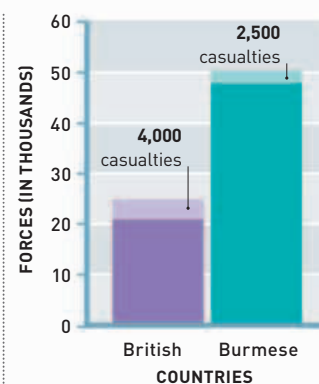
Early Benz
A side view of a gasoline-driven, three-wheeled Benz Motorwagen. German engineer, Karl Benz, patented his design in 1886 and the motorcar was born.



British troops of the Somersetshire Light Infantry cross a river in Burma, during the Anglo-Burmese War.

EMANCIPATION FINALLY ARRIVED FOR SLAVES IN CUBA in October 1886, after a long struggle. Although Britain had decided to end the slave trade in 1807 and abolish the practice of slavery in 1833, Spain and other European colonial powers did not follow suit. In 1817, the Spanish agreed a treaty with Britain to stop the slave trade—and then ignored it. With the loss of most of its Central and South American colonies, Spain turned to its remaining sugar islands of **Cuba** and **Puerto Rico** to refill its coffers. To this end, slavery not only continued, but increased over the course of the 19th century, although British antislavery patrols tried to stop ships between the west coast of Africa and Havana. Despite their efforts, the numbers continued to rise. In 1840, around 14,500 slaves were brought to Cuba; by 1859 this number reached nearly 30,500. By 1866, slave imports had fallen to just over 1,000 and the following year, the slave trade was finally outlawed by the Spanish legislature.

However, this act did not free the considerable number of slaves on the island. Years of gradual abolition culminated in a royal **decree** that **emancipated the slaves** in 1886. Meanwhile on January 1, Britain annexed **Burma**, heralding a long period of insurgency.



Third Burmese War
Although the war lasted a few weeks, the Burmese insurgency that followed lasted until 1899, claiming many more lives—as shown in this chart.

The annexation was the culmination of the **Third Anglo-Burmese War** in 1885, which had only lasted a few weeks. The war was triggered by Burmese king **Thibaw**’s negotiations with France over a political alliance and the construction of a railway line to the Indian border. Britain was unable to air its concerns as Thibaw refused a visit from the British envoy. Britain had already annexed Lower Burma after the previous war (see 1852) and the British decided to react by now seizing **Mandalay** and northern Burma. Thibaw was deposed and the territory was annexed to India, giving Britain control of the former kingdom. Although this marked the end of the official war, there was a sporadic guerrilla campaign by the Burmese that would continue to cause unrest in the region for another four years.

January 4 First successful appendectomy performed

March 31 Bechuanaland (present-day Botswana) becomes British protectorate

Tanganyika becomes German protectorate

Indian political party, **Indian National Congress**, meets for first time

Germany annexes **Marshall Islands**, Pacific Ocean

Belgium’s **Leopold II** (1835–1909) establishes **Congo Free State**

Serbia defeated in war with **Bulgaria**

Development of first automobiles by German engineers **Gottlieb Daimler** (1834–1900) and **Karl Benz** (1844–1929)

One of the world’s first skyscrapers built in **Chicago**

September 18 Eastern Rumelia unites with **Bulgaria**

November Third Anglo-Burmese War (to 1886) leads to British annexation of Burmese territory

January 1 Britain annexes **Burma**

January 29 Karl Benz patents first modern gasoline-driven automobile

March 3 Treaty of Bucharest officially ends **Serbo-Bulgarian War**

May 8 Soft drink **Coca-Cola** first sold

September 4 Indian Wars: Geronimo chief of Apache surrenders warriors to US Army

October 7 Spain abolishes slavery in **Cuba**